saying a word and you would be intimidated,' is how a bureaucrat explained Jaya power to me once.

I had met Jayalalithaa once in Chennai, soon after her remarkable comeback win in Tamil Nadu in 2011. I had taken a Ruskin Bond book as a gift because I was told he was one of her favourite authors. She was polite and gracious, thanked me for the book, and then said, 'I will now have very little time to read. The DMK has left behind a mess, I will have to clean it up.' With her perfect convent-school English accent, she sounded as though she meant every word. I didn't dare counter-question her.

In fact, taking on Jayalalithaa in any form could be a hazardous business. I experienced it first-hand when we got a criminal defamation notice from her office for our highly popular weekly comic programme, *The Week That Wasn't*. Stand-up comedians Cyrus Broacha and Kunal Vijayakar would every week lampoon political figures—Sonia, Rahul, Modi, Mamata. No one was spared (except Bal Thackeray because we feared the Shiv Sena would then attack our Mumbai office!).

Then we made the mistake of showing a Jayalalithaa-like character, with a fun gag on her wealth and relationship with onetime close friend Sasikala. It was all meant to be good-humoured, but Jayalalithaa clearly didn't see the funny side. We had a legal battle on our hands. I asked a Chennai-based lawyer to help. 'Whatever you do, never mess with Jayalalithaa,' was his friendly advice (incidentally, the case is still being fought in a Chennai court with our efforts at an out-of-court settlement not having succeeded).

It's a lesson many politicians and even well-wishers of the AIADMK leader have learnt over the years. Cho Ramaswamy, the satirist and editor, was among the few who had some access to Jayalalithaa. But when I visited him at the office of his magazine *Tughlaq* in February 2014, he claimed Jayalalithaa wasn't meeting him any longer. 'She is angry with me because I am supporting Modi for prime minister. She wants me to support her instead!' he said with an exasperated look.

Mamata had never claimed she wanted to be prime minister. Her heart and head were firmly located in the by-lanes of Kolkata. Not so Jayalalithaa. She did have a lurking ambition to be prime minister one day.